



REPORT WRITING

CHAPTER 3

- 3.1 Introduction
- 3.2 Report structure
- 3.3 Summary



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Report writing¹

3.1 Introduction

All written assignments must follow specific structures that allow the document to be easily read and understood. This chapter provides a useful guide for students preparing written work in a formal report format. A formal report should contain the following sections, in the order given.

- 1 Assignment cover sheet
- 2 Letter of transmittal (not always required — check your assessment instructions)
- 3 Title page
- 4 Executive summary
- 5 Table of contents
- 6 Introduction
- 7 The body
- 8 Conclusions
- 9 Recommendations (sometimes not required)
- 10 List of references (LOR)
- 11 Glossary (not always required)
- 12 Appendices

3.2 Report structure

This section provides detailed guidance on each section of the formal report listed.

3.2.1 Assignment cover sheet

The cover sheet protects the assignment and identifies the student and the due date. It also provides verification of submission date and authentication of original work through the student's signature. This signature on the statement of original work is legally binding and means that the student agrees that any unoriginal work in the assignment has been appropriately referenced. Some universities provide assignment and course specific cover sheets for students to use.

3.2.2 Letter of transmittal

A letter of transmittal enables the writer of the report to establish contact with the receiver, and acts as the formal record of delivery of the report.

When including a letter of transmittal be careful to read the instructions provided in your assessment information. In some assessments you will be required to develop or use a letterhead or logo on your letter. When this is the case, the logo would appear on the top left of the page. The letter of transmittal should be fully left-justified (with the exception of the sender's address) and should use open punctuation (no commas or full stops in the address or heading section of the letter). In general, letters of

¹ The contribution to the development of this section on plagiarism by Dr Lesley Willcoxon is gratefully acknowledged.

transmittal use single spacing within the parts of the letter and double spacing between the parts (i.e. paragraphs or heading and greeting). See figure 3.1 for an example.

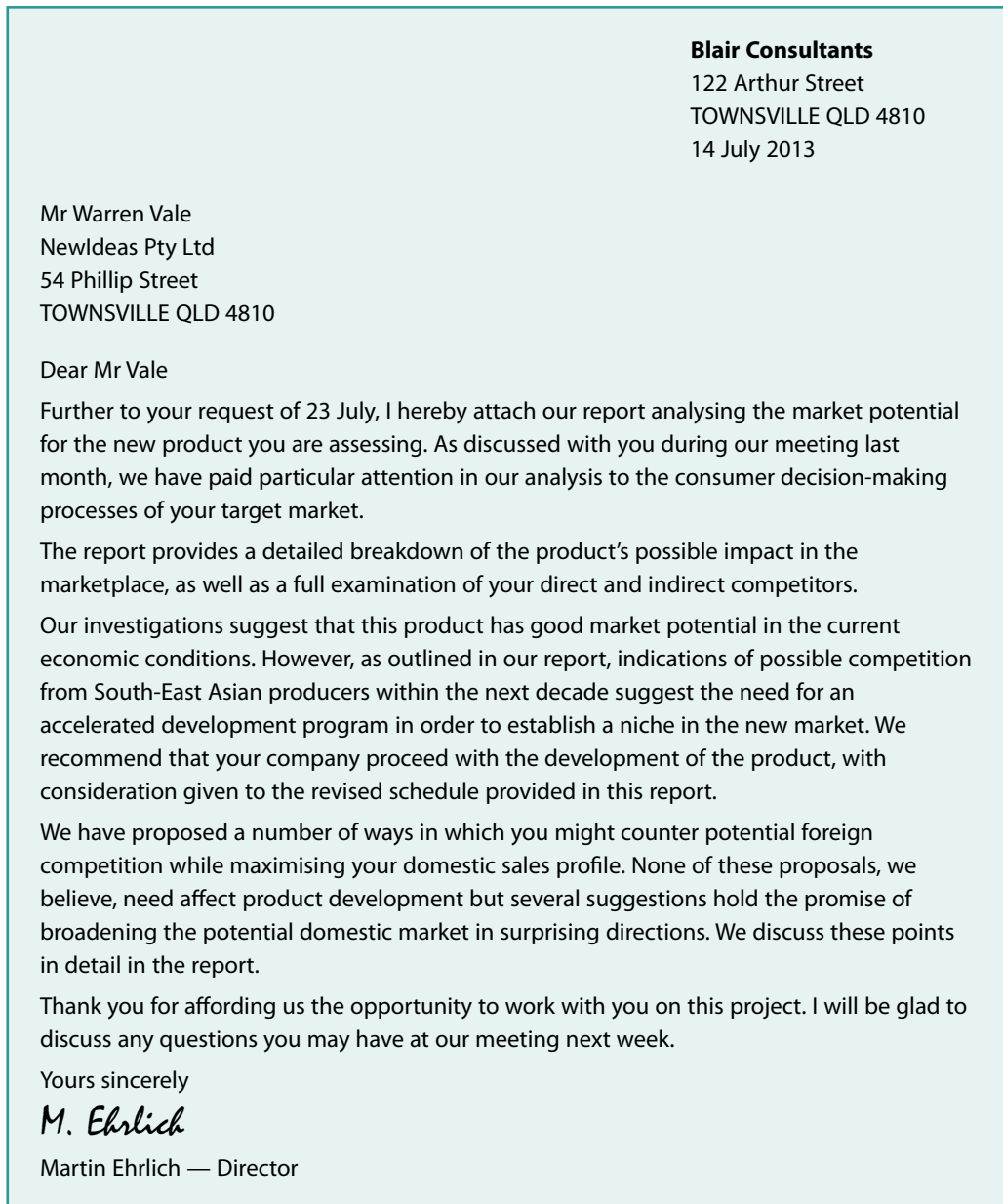


FIGURE 3.1 Example of a letter of transmittal

The letter should be addressed to the person who requested the report (in your assignments it is permissible to use a fictitious person), and the return address of the sender should be left-justified, unless official letterhead is used (your name should not appear at this point). The city and state elements of the sender's return address and of the receiver's address should be entered in capital letters.

The date of writing should be in the format *day/month/year*, with the month written in full and not abbreviated as a number (e.g. *3 March 2009* and not *3/3/09*). Avoid the use of suffixes such as *st* or *th* after the day (i.e. do not write *4th March*).

The body of the letter of transmittal should generally take the form of a 'good or neutral news' letter (although in some cases a 'bad news' letter may be appropriate). That is, it should contain:

- *a positive opening*: usually a straightforward statement indicating that the report is enclosed
- *further explanation*: generally includes a brief overview of the report, as well as brief details of the conclusions reached. Acknowledgement of any people who assisted in the report's preparation may be included here
- *a goodwill message*: a courteous closing in which you indicate what has to be done next, express your pleasure at being able to provide the information in the report and state your willingness to discuss the report in person. Refer to the example in figure 3.1.

3.2.3 Title page

The title page is placed after the cover sheet and letter of transmittal and should provide the following:

- the title of the report, or restatement of assignment or essay question, usually also indicating the question number if a choice is given
- the name of the person for whom the report was prepared (instructor or client); sometimes the tutorial group or tutor's name is also required
- the date of submission of the report
- the student's name (s) and student number (s).

Some instructors also require a statement of the length of the report (number of words). If required this should also appear on the title page.

Note: a title page is essential for all assessment items regardless of how they are submitted. This means that electronically submitted assessment items should also have a title page with the same information. See figure 3.2 for an example of a title page.

3.2.4 Executive summary

The executive summary provides the reader with the report's major purpose, the analytical processes, the findings and the recommendations. It is so called because executives traditionally do not have sufficient time to read complete reports, yet need to extract sufficient information to make informed decisions. The executive summary should encourage the reader to go on to read the full report. It can also serve as a quick reference for the writer of the report at some future stage.

The executive summary is an extremely important component of any formal report and should be prepared *carefully*, rather than as an afterthought. Several drafts will be necessary to get it 'right'.



FIGURE 3.2 Example of an assignment title page

The executive summary will rarely be more than one page in length and should not contain subheadings, direct quotes, bullet points or unnecessary descriptive information. It should also be single-line spaced. It should contain a brief statement of the following:

- the purpose (objectives) and scope of the report
- the type of analysis conducted (and methods used)
- the most important and significant findings, in summary form
- the most important and significant recommendations.

It should be a ‘stand-alone’ document that encompasses the important points of the report it accompanies. Table 3.1 provides a guide to the approximate length of the executive summary.

TABLE 3.1 A guide to the length of an executive summary	
REPORT LENGTH (WORDS)	EXECUTIVE SUMMARY LENGTH (WORDS)
1500	200–300
2000	250–350
3000	450–550

Note: The word count of the report does not include the executive summary, letter of transmittal, table of contents, figures, tables, references or appendices.

Most people recommend that the executive summary be written last, after the report has been prepared. This does not mean that it appears last in the report. It simply recognises that once the report is completed and the conclusions and recommendations have been made, it is far easier to write an overall summary of that report. Avoid providing executive summaries that read like a table of contents. That is, do not just list the things you did in the order you did them; it should really be more of a summary of the main activities and findings of the report.

The executive summary should be given a page number using the lower-case roman numeral *i* (if it runs to a second page, this should be marked with a *ii*). Remember also that the executive summary must appear before the table of contents.

3.2.5 Table of contents

The table of contents should be listed on a new page of the report and, as for the executive summary, this page is numbered using a roman numeral (e.g. *ii*). Sections are listed in the order in which they appear in the report and the corresponding page numbers should be shown. Page 1 of the report, usually the introduction, follows the table of contents, and all subsequent sections are then numbered sequentially using Arabic numerals (2, 3, 4 etc.).

When setting out your table of contents, the main section numbers should appear against the left-hand margin. There should then be one tab space to the heading of that section. Corresponding subsection numbers should appear indented one tab space from the left-hand margin, or under the first letter of the main heading, and subsection headings indented a further tab space to the right. Dot leaders may be used between the entry and page number to improve the clarity of the document. There are generally single spaces between subsections and double spaces between sections (see figure 3.3).

If a section covers more than one page, only the page number on which the section begins need be shown in the table of contents.

Note: If submitting a report with a computer-generated table of contents, the formatting guideline outlined here might not strictly apply. Compare the table of contents at the front of this handbook, generated by computer, with the manually constructed one shown in figure 3.3. Care should be taken to follow the example shown in figure 3.3 as closely as possible.

Sub-subsections should be treated in a similar fashion; that is, two tab spaces from the left-hand margin or under the first letter of the subheading title. Again, refer to the example provided in figure 3.3. It is essential that all major headings and subheadings be clearly identifiable.

All appendices should be listed with their titles and corresponding page numbers. Following this, tables, then figures and then graphs should also be listed separately with their titles and corresponding page numbers. See section 1.3.3 for differences between tables and figures.

3.2.6 Introduction

The introduction has three parts.

- *The authorisation and purpose of the report* tells the reader who has commissioned the work and why the report is being produced.
- *Hindrances* are any limitations encountered in the production of the report that may affect the results or the ability of the writer to complete the report. This does not include personal hindrances, but refers to issues in relation to data collection, availability or access to information and information that may be confidential in nature or subject to change post the assessment being submitted (for example, legislation that is currently under review or policy that has been flagged for change post an election result).
- *The scope of the report* summarises what the report covers, how information will be presented in the report, where the information for the report comes from and how it will be gathered (e.g. questionnaires or other research). Be careful here

once again not to simply reproduce the table of contents: this should be an overview or summary of what will be done, not a bit-by-bit reproduction. Focus on the important elements.

TABLE OF CONTENTS		Page
<i>Executive summary</i>		i
1.	<i>Introduction</i>	1
1.1	Authorisation	1
1.2	Limitations	1
1.3	Scope of the report	2
2.	<i>The current situation</i>	2
2.1	Basis for operations	3
2.1.1	Organisational structure	5
2.1.2	Operations code	6
2.2	Sales department	7
3.	<i>Planned development</i>	8
3.1	Objectives of the company	9
3.1.1	Assumptions	9
3.2	Priorities in implementing the plans	10
4.	<i>Conclusions</i>	11
5.	<i>Recommendations</i>	11
<i>List of references</i>		12
<i>Appendices</i>		
Appendix 1 — The organisational chart		13
Appendix 2 — Competitor analysis		14
<i>List of tables</i>		
Table 1 — The financial structure		6
<i>List of figures</i>		
Figure 1.1 — Graph of financial data		10

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FIGURE 3.3 Sample table of contents

3.2.7 Body

This is the main part of the report and contains the discussions and analysis. The information in this section should be presented in a logical sequence, using paragraphing to separate ideas. As a general rule, each paragraph should contain one main idea. Headings and subheadings should be used to identify each section and introduce new ideas or directions.

It is *very important* in this section to ensure that theoretical evidence or research findings are used to support the discussion. Throughout the report, answers should be provided to the following questions.

- How is this known and who says so? (Usually some sort of reference is needed to address this question.)

- Why is this so? (Here you would cite research findings or results from investigations of data and information. You may also use theoretical frameworks to support your findings.)
- Why was this option, action or design selected and what were the alternatives? (You need to justify your approach and recommendations using theory and research results.)
- How should this recommendation be implemented and are there any potential impediments that should be considered? (Here you would outline the implementation issues and reiterate research findings and theoretical support.)

3.2.8 Conclusions

This section should essentially summarise the main points or findings of the assignment. It should be based on the information presented in the body. It is essential that you do not introduce any new information or ideas at this stage and the use of direct quotations should be avoided. The conclusion should answer the question: what do the findings mean?

It is important to ensure that your conclusions are consistent with the outline given in the introduction. For this reason, it is generally recommended that the introduction be written after the main report. The conclusion should answer the following questions. Was the purpose of the report fulfilled? Have the specified sources of information been used? Have the areas stated been adequately tackled?

3.2.9 Recommendations

Recommendations should be presented only when specifically requested. They are based on the conclusions and are the suggested options for solving the problem or problems that made writing the report necessary. Recommendations should be brief statements outlining a specific course of action suggested by your research, for example, 'That library hours be extended to 11.00 pm on weeknights'.

It should be clearly demonstrated that detailed thought has been given to how the recommendations should be *implemented*, as well as what the resource *implications* might be for these. Consider the following questions.

- Are the recommendations *realistic* in the light of current environmental conditions (economic times, likely competitor reaction, government policy and consumer reactions)?
- Has sufficient thought been given to *timing* and *priorities*? When do the recommendations need to be implemented and in what order?
- Are the proposals *feasible*? Are there the financial, physical and human resources to support them?

3.2.10 Bibliography or LOR

Remember, an *LOR* (list of references) is an alphabetical listing of any material actually *cited* in the report. A *bibliography* is an alphabetical listing of all the sources of information that have been read, used or referenced in researching and preparing the report. A bibliography will, therefore, contain any additional information that was reviewed in compiling the report, whether or not it was specifically cited. While a formal report may require the inclusion of both, generally *only an LOR is required in student assignments*.

3.2.11 Glossary

A glossary is required only if a considerable number of technical terms have been used in the report, which may need to be explained to the reader. It is a form of mini-dictionary. It should start on a separate page. The term to be explained should be entered on the left and a definition, or reference, added on the right.

Be sure to reference correctly any definitions that have been taken from another author's work.

3.2.12 Appendices

Appendices generally contain:

- material that is too bulky to include in the body of the report
- material that is essential to explain a point but if included in the body of the report, would distract the reader from the main message.

All appendices should be numbered sequentially (i.e. 1, 2, 3 and so on) and given a title. It is essential that direct reference be made in the main body of the report to each appendix. This will enable the reader to understand the material presented in the appendix in the context of the report.

Each appendix should begin on a new page, and each should usually contain only one major piece of information. However, if you have a number of tables, figures or graphs in which the information is interrelated, then an appendix can contain more than one piece of information. There is no limit to the number of appendices you can have (providing they are relevant).

Appendices usually include questionnaires, charts, maps, tables, extracts and so on. *It is very important that any material included in appendices is referenced correctly.* For example, if using a diagram from a textbook, there must be a reference for the source of that diagram.

3.3 Summary

A report is a special type of written communication used to provide concise information, and in some cases opinions, on a specific subject. Reports should be structured so that readers are guided through the main points. All relevant information should be included so that, after reading the report, readers will have a clear understanding of the key issues concerned.

Although most reports follow a fairly standard format, report layout may vary depending on the intended audience. Formal reports should include an assignment cover sheet, title page, letter of transmittal, executive summary, table of contents, introduction, the main body of the report, conclusions, recommendations, LOR, glossary (if required) and appendices. Each of these components has been discussed in detail in this chapter.